

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 50

Culture (OWC): [Ganda \(FK07\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1931-1932

Coverage Date: 1931-1932

Place Coverage: Uganda

Section Title(S): (C) The Birth Of Twins

This meant that, in a chief's case, the period of special observances lasted very much longer than with a peasant; but this did not inconvenience him seriously because it was one of the duties of his leading subordinate chief to perform rites on his behalf. It fell to the latter not only to announce the birth from the roof of the house and to deliver all the preliminary messages but also to endure the discomfort of going unwashed and unshaven.

[622
Community Heads](#)

[845
Difficult And Unusual Births](#)

[851
Social Placement](#)

All this ceremonial is now very largely obsolete. An increasing number of births take place in the village maternity centres, which makes the rites that followed immediately after the birth impossible, and the general feeling seems to be that this absolves the parents from the necessity of performing any others—or, possibly, makes them useless. In the case of the twin ceremonial, the dancing has been specifically forbidden by a law of the native parliament which prohibits all obscene dances, mentioning these by name; and most of the other rites have been suppressed by missionary disapproval, made effective by the educated native authorities and genuinely shared by some of the natives who are most attached to old traditions. But some celebration is still thought essential here, though it is confined almost to the actual eating of the feast. It is still the need to have this done by the right persons that makes it important to know the father of an unmarried girl's child. Again, at a wedding which I saw of a girl who was married by missionaries without her father's consent, the joke of all the onlookers was "If you have twins, where will you take them? To the Fathers?"

[177
Acculturation And Culture Contact](#)

[656
Government Regulation](#)

[797
Missions](#)

[846
Postnatal Care](#)

I also saw a naming ceremony of dead twins. There was no dancing, singing, or drumming; merely a series of  51 offerings of coffee-berries by the guests to the parents and to "little *Salongo* and *Nalongo*"—in this case grown-up persons—who stood in a row outside the door of the house. But even this had gathered together relatives who had not met for years, and the father, who was quite a poor man, killed for the feast three goats and a sheep, which might be worth altogether about twenty-seven shillings.

[553
Naming](#)

[845
Difficult And Unusual Births](#)

*755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511*

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)